

Pagodas

Tiered towers with multiple eaves, Chinese pagodas evolved from multi-storey timber towers created before the arrival of Buddhism in the first century CE, but share a heritage with Indian stupas.

Primarily built of wood or brick, the structures themselves were hollow – their main function was to house religious relics beneath the ground, although a few were built in scenic isolation as elements of *feng shui*, and some began to appear on palaces as decorative features. Most early examples, built before the tenth century, had square bases, but later versions were built on polygonal plans. The shapes of the eaves and decorative details varied with time and location, while tiers changed from straight to an upwardly curving style dating from the 12th century. The earliest surviving Chinese timber pagoda is the White Horse Temple in Luoyang (founded 68 CE, rebuilt in the 13th century), while the oldest brick pagoda is the 12-sided Songyue monastery (523 CE, opposite). Buddhists introduced pagodas to Japan in the seventh century CE. They are highly resistant to earthquakes, owing to their structural flexibility.

